NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.
1NT Opening: 15-17 points
2NT Opening: 20-21 points
1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit
2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.
In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.
Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 6♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♣10

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: East
Lead: ♦K

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: South
Lead: ♥J

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: West
Lead: ♣2

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ A Q 10 2 ♥ K 7 ♦ K Q 7 3 ♣ K 7 5	
♠ 9 6 ♥ Q 10 8 3 ♦ J 9 6 2 ♣ Q J 3		♠ 7 4 ♥ 9 6 5 ♦ A 10 8 4 ♣ 10 9 8 2
	♠ K J 8 5 3 ♥ A J 4 2 ♦ 5 ♣ A 6 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2♥
Pass	3♠	Pass	4NT[1]
Pass	5♦[2]	Pass	6♠
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 1 ace

6♠ by North
Lead: ♣10

Partner's 2♥ bid is a transfer; he expects you to bid 2♠. However, with such great ♠ support and an outside doubleton your hand now revalues to 18 points - more than an opening 1NT. You indicate this with a jump to 3♠. This is called a "Super-Accept". Partner now bids 4NT. What do you answer?

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Blackwood, and with one Ace you answer 5♦. Partner bids 6♠ and everybody passes.

Obviously you aren't going to hold up on the ♣ lead. It won't matter where you take it, but assume you win in your hand.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 2

Since the ♦ loser is a sure thing you will need to find somewhere to discard a ♣. There are three possibilities:Finesse East for the ♥Q. (50% chance)Try to drop the ♥Q by ruffing the third round. (also about 50%)Establish a ♦ honor. (100% certain)

First pull trumps, ending in dummy. It takes two rounds. Next play the ♦5 toward your ♦Q. East wins this and plays another ♣. Win the ♣, come to your hand with the ♥K, then play your good ♦Q, discarding dummy's losing ♣.

You will need to ruff two ♥s in your hand, but the rest of the tricks are yours.

This was pretty easy because the trumps split 2-2.

If they had been 3-1 you would have had to leave the last trump undrawn until after you had ruffed two ♥s in your hand.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

♠ 10 9 7 2
♥ A 8
♦ 10 8 3
♣ 10 9 6 4

♠ A J 6
♥ Q J 9 7 5 2
♦ 6 4 2
♣ 8



♠ K 4
♥ K 10 4 3
♦ A 7 5
♣ K Q J 2

♠ Q 8 5 3
♥ 6
♦ K Q J 9
♣ A 7 5 3

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	Pass
2♦	Pass	2♥	Pass
4♥			
All Pass			

4♥ by East
Lead: ♦K

With 10 points and a 6-card ♥ suit you want to transfer. You say 2♦ and partner bids 2♥.

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You know you want to play in ♥s since partner will have at least 2 of them. Your problem is whether to merely invite with 3♥ or go ahead and bid the game. Since partner has either 15, 16 or 17 points you should probably just bid 4♥. The worst thing that could happen is that partner would be playing game with only 25 points.

The contract would be 4♥ played by West.

East plays 4♥. South leads the ♦K. Do you hold up or not?

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 4

There is no reason to hold up. Besides, you have bigger problems to deal with.

After you take the ♦A at trick one you have four fast losers staring you in the face the instant you lose the lead. So do you pull trumps now?

No, you dare not touch trumps yet - remember those 4 fast losers.

You cannot avoid the ♥A and ♣A, so you must get rid of one of the ♦ losers before you play trumps.

Win the ♦A, play the ♠K, then finesse the ♠J. If the finesse works discard a ♦ on the ♠A, then pull trumps. If the finesse fails you will go down 2 instead of 1.

You made it - on a 50% chance.

When the cards MUST lie in a particular way for the contract to be makeable, just assume that's the way they lie and go for it.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ 7 4 3 ♥ A Q 7 2 ♦ 7 5 3 ♣ K 8 4	
♠ K 9 8 2 ♥ J 10 9 8 ♦ J 2 ♣ 9 7 3	N W E S	♠ A 6 ♥ 6 3 ♦ Q 10 9 8 4 ♣ Q J 10 6
	♠ Q J 10 5 ♥ K 5 4 ♦ A K 6 ♣ A 5 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	2♣	Pass	2♠
Pass	2NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♥J

In response to partner's Stayman bid you show your 4-card ♠ suit. Partner now bids 2NT.

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You may disagree with the Stayman bid on 3-4-3-3 distribution. In any case, 2NT is invitational, so with 17 points you say 3NT.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♥J.

Winner List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 3/4 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 7/8

West's ♥J lead probably means ♥s won't be 3-3, so you will need to get 2 ♠ tricks.

Suppose you win the first trick and plunk down the ♠Q. If East wins with a doubleton ♠ honor you will only be able to win 1 ♠ since West will sit there with ♠ A 9 or ♠ K 9 behind your ♠ J 10.

Instead, win the first trick in dummy and play a small ♠ toward the ♠ Q J 10. East will play low and West must take his ♠ honor. But you can win his return, enter dummy and play another ♠ toward your hand. If you are lucky, East will be forced to play an honor and you can toss your ♠5.

This plan, leading toward your ♠ holding twice, will succeed the majority of the time.

It only fails if West holds 4 or more ♠s headed by A K.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ J 9 2 ♥ J 8 5 ♦ J 10 4 ♣ J 7 5 2	
♠ A 7 4 ♥ A 9 4 ♦ 8 6 3 ♣ A K Q 9		♠ 8 6 5 ♥ K 7 2 ♦ A Q 9 ♣ 10 6 4 3
	♠ K Q 10 3 ♥ Q 10 6 3 ♦ K 7 5 2 ♣ 8	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1NT	Pass	2NT	Pass
3NT			
All Pass			

3NT by West
Lead: ♣2

A square hand, no 4-card Major, and 9 points. This is the very hand that the book said to bid 2NT with. And when you do, partner says 3NT which you pass.

The contract would be 3NT played by East.

West plays 3NT. North leads the ♣2. You must be living right, North gives you a trick with the opening lead.

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 4 :: Total = 8

You got a good break on the opening lead, now you need only one more winner. There is **NO CHANCE** of creating another winner in ♠s, ♥s or ♣s, so your second good break is that you know it will have to be ♦s.

You **COULD** lead toward dummy's ♦Q, finessing North for the ♦K. That would be a perfectly good 50% chance. But there is an even better play if you look carefully.

Play a ♦ from your hand and if North plays low insert the ♦9. Much of the time South will win with the ♦J or ♦10. If so you are no worse off, you play North for the ♦K. But if it happens that North was dealt both the ♦J and ♦10 then South will have to win that trick with the ♦K, or perhaps not even win it at all!

As you see, the Deep Finesse of the ♦9 pays off here, where the straightforward finesse of the ♦Q would lose the contract. Two chances are definitely better than one.

But what if North has played the ♦10, splitting his honors?

You would put on dummy's ♦Q and South would win the ♦K. But you aren't down yet! Later you lead another ♦ toward dummy's ♦ A 9 and finesse North for the ♦J.